

10 Common Phone Scams Targeting Seniors

A Guide to Staying Safe & Confident

Technology should make life easier, not more stressful. At NeighborTech, we believe knowledge is the best defense. Here are the top 10 phone scams currently targeting seniors and how you can spot them.

1. The Grandparent Scam

The caller pretends to be a grandchild in immediate trouble (accident, arrest, or stranded abroad) and begs you not to tell their parents while asking for money via wire transfer or gift cards.

Red Flag: Extreme urgency, secrecy, and a request for unconventional payment methods.

2. Government Impersonation (IRS/Social Security)

Scammers claim to be from the IRS or Social Security Administration, alleging you owe back taxes or that your benefits are suspended due to "fraudulent activity" on your number.

Red Flag: Threats of arrest or legal action. Remember: Government agencies never call to demand immediate payment or sensitive info.

3. The Tech Support Scam

A "technician" calls claiming they've detected a virus on your computer. They ask for remote access to "fix" it, then install malware or charge you hundreds for a fake repair.

Red Flag: Unsolicited calls about your computer's health. Legitimate companies like Microsoft or Apple will never call you out of the blue.

4. Medicare & Healthcare Scams

Callers offer "free" medical supplies (like back braces), DNA testing, or new Medicare cards to trick you into giving up your Medicare number for fraudulent billing.

Red Flag: Offers of "free" medical equipment or services that require your Medicare ID over the phone.

5. Lottery & Sweepstakes Scams

You're told you've won a major prize (like Publishers Clearing House) but must pay "processing fees" or "taxes" upfront before the winnings can be released.

Red Flag: Being asked to pay money to receive a prize. If you didn't enter, you didn't win!

6. Amazon & Package Delivery Scams

An automated call claims there is a problem with an expensive order or a lost package. They ask you to "press 1" to speak to an agent who then asks for your credit card or login info.

Red Flag: High-pressure calls about orders you don't remember placing.

7. The "Can You Hear Me?" Scam

The caller asks a simple question like "Can you hear me?" or "Is this [Your Name]?" They are trying to record you saying "Yes" to use as a voice signature for fraudulent charges.

Red Flag: A stranger asking "Can you hear me?" as soon as you pick up. If you're unsure, just hang up.

8. Romance Scams

While often starting online, these move to the phone. A scammer builds a relationship over weeks, then suddenly has a "crisis" and needs financial help.

Red Flag: Someone you've never met in person asking for money, especially via wire or crypto.

9. Charity Scams

Fake charities call following a disaster or during the holidays, using names that sound very similar to well-known organizations to solicit donations.

Red Flag: High pressure to donate "right now" and refusal to provide written information about the charity.

10. Utility Shut-Off Scams

Scammers claim to be from your electric or water company, threatening to shut off your service in the next hour unless you pay a "past due" balance immediately.

Red Flag: Threats of immediate disconnection. Utility companies provide multiple written notices before any shut-off.

5 Golden Rules for Phone Safety

- **When in Doubt, Hang Up:** You are never being rude by protecting your privacy.
- **Don't Trust Caller ID:** Scammers can "spoof" numbers to look like they are calling from your local area or a government office.
- **Never Give Personal Info:** Never share your Social Security, Medicare, or Credit Card numbers with an unsolicited caller.
- **Call Them Back:** If you're worried a call might be real, hang up and call the company or agency back using a verified number from their official website or your bill.
- **Slow Down:** Scammers use urgency to make you panic. Take a breath and talk to a trusted friend or family member first.

Need help staying safe?

NeighborTech provides in-home education and security setups to help you navigate the digital world with confidence.

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